Although this recipe uses coconut milk as its base and key Thai flavorings, it makes no pretense of authenticity. No extra salt should be necessary, as *nam pla* is salty.

thai chicken soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

4 stalks lemongrass, bruised and cut into ½in (1cm) lengths
7oz (200g) galangal, peeled and diced
5 kaffir lime leaves, bruised
1 chicken leg
2 cups water
2 small red chiles
1 litre (1¾ pints) coconut milk
1 tbsp *nam pla* or Asian fish sauce
juice of 3 limes
3 scallions, finely chopped
2 tbsp chopped cilantro

1 Put the lemongrass, galangal, lime leaves, chicken, and water in a pan and bring to a boil. Simmer uncovered for 30 minutes, or until the chicken is cooked. Remove with a slotted spoon, dice the flesh, discarding the skin and bones, and set aside.

2 Add the chiles to the pan and bring the soup back to a boil. Pour in the coconut milk and heat slowly—you want the soup to become hot enough for the flavors to infuse the coconut milk without coming to a boil.

3 Strain the soup into a clean pan or tureen. Remove the chiles from the sieve and cut into slivers. Add the *nam pla*, lime juice, scallions, cilantro, and chicken to the soup, then taste to check the seasoning. Serve garnished with the chile slivers.



CHILES
Look for fresh, bright, shiny-looking chiles, and avoid any that have soft patches or look wrinkled. Wrapped in a biodegradable plastic bag, they will keep in the crisper drawer of the refrigerator for up to 2 weeks.